

internet access; today, that number has grown to 900 million, with the goal of reaching 1.2 billion by 2026. This rapid expansion of connectivity was crucial in enabling all citizens to participate in the digital economy.

Another major challenge was overcoming resistance to change. Disruptive initiatives like this often face pushback, especially over concerns related to data protection and privacy. However, India addressed these concerns robustly by enacting a data protection law that safeguards individuals' privacy.

Digital literacy was also a focus area. Given India's diversity and large population, educating citizens on how to interact with the government digitally was essential. A comprehensive programme reached over 400 million people, including a significant number in rural areas and among women. This effort has empowered millions to navigate the digital landscape and connect with the government more efficiently.

The benefits of this digital transformation extend beyond governance. The democratisation of technology has led to real empowerment and wealth creation. For example, over the past decade, 55 million homes have been built for poor families in India, with 80% of these homes owned by women. This achievement is a direct result of transparent service delivery enabled by technology. As a result of Digital Government and IndiaDPI being central to India's governance paradigm, we have also created one of the world's fastest-growing digital and innovation economies—growing nearly three times faster than the rest of the economy.

It is important here to say that the role of artificial intelligence (AI) in this transformation is significant. AI is often discussed as a buzzword or the next big thing, but it's more accurately described as a kinetic enabler of the next wave of our digital economy. For both government and



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businesses, AI adoption is crucial as it drives efficiency and redefines success across every legacy application and technology segment. IndiaDPI + AI will sharpen governance, make it more targeted, and help realise the vision of smart governance.

IndiaDPI has redrawn the technology landscape in another important way: it reflects a broader global trend where the once-exclusive control of technology by a few countries is being challenged by the rise of open-source platforms. India is leading this approach in AI as well. As the current Chair of the Global Partnership on AI (GPAI), India has spearheaded efforts to ensure that democracies play a leading role in shaping the future

of technology. This shift presents an opportunity for democracies worldwide to collaborate and lead in shaping the future of technology. The last 10 years in India have been transformative and have positioned the country for another decade of economic expansion and opportunities. Technology, innovation, and AI will play starring roles as India strides towards becoming one of the top three economies in the world. This goal is well within reach. Let's work together to make it a reality. **BT**

The author is former Minister of State, Ministry of Electronics and IT. Views are personal